8TH GRADE SCIENCE • CHAPTER 5 PROJECT

Fossil Record Projects!

Make rock layers, bury "fossils," and dig into the evidence for yourself!

Name: _____



How It Works

PROJECT 1
Everyone does it
Layers in a Jar
Make rock layers in minutes and bury your own "fossils."

PROJECT 2
You pick ONE
Your Choice
Strata in a Cup, Myth-Busters, or a News Report. See the back!

TIME 2
Weeks for BOTH
Due Date!
Both projects due:
_____

Project 1: Layers in a Jar (Required for Everyone)

The big idea: Some people say rock layers took a very long time to form. But when Mount St. Helens erupted in 1980, it laid down hundreds of feet of layers in just days! In this experiment, you'll watch layers form in minutes, just like the Flood could have done on a much bigger scale.

- 🫙 Clear jar with a lid
- 🏖️ Sand
- 🪴 Garden dirt
- 🪨 Small rocks or gravel
- 💧 Water
- 🦖 3–5 tiny toy animals or shells
- 📱 Phone or camera

1 🦖
Fill It
Fill the jar halfway with sand, dirt, and rocks. Drop in your "fossils."

2 💧
Add Water
Fill with water until almost full. Screw the lid on tight!

3 🌊
Shake It
Shake hard for 30 seconds. Then set it down and don't touch it.

4 📸
Snap Pics
Take pictures at 1 minute, 10 minutes, and 1 day. Count the layers!

💡 **Use a jar with a tight lid so it doesn't leak!**

💡 **Ask a parent before using garden dirt.**

✏️ Your Write-Up (about half a page)

Answer these 4 questions: **1)** How many layers formed? **2)** How long did it take? **3)** Where did your "fossils" end up? **4)** How does this connect to the Flood or Mount St. Helens?

Turn In for Project 1

Bring your jar (or your 3 pictures) and your write-up. Be ready to show the class!

PROJECT 2 • CHOOSE ONE

Pick Your Adventure!

Choose Option A, B, or C. You only do one!

Circle your choice: A. Strata in a Cup • B. Myth-Busters • C. News Report

A 🥤 Strata in a Cup

Build rock layers with a "tree" standing up through all of them, like a real **polystrate fossil**. A tree can't stand for ages waiting to be buried, so the layers had to form fast!

You need

Clear cup • 3–5 colors of sand • pretzel rod or straw • index card

Steps

1. Stand your "tree" in the middle of the cup.
2. Pour in 1 inch of sand. Add the next color on top. Make at least 4 layers.
3. Make sure the tree goes through every layer.
4. On the card, label the layers and write 3–4 sentences on why this shows fast burial.

B 🔍 Missing Link Myth-Busters

Be a detective! Pick one famous "missing link" and find out if it was really an in-between creature.

Pick one

- **Piltdown Man:** human skull + ape jaw
- **Nebraska Man:** made from a pig's tooth!
- **Archaeoraptor:** two fossils glued together
- **Lucy:** most likely an extinct ape
- **Neanderthals:** 100% human

Make a poster with 3 parts

1. **The Claim**: what people said it was
2. **The Evidence**: what scientists found out
3. **The Verdict**: real or BUSTED?

Add a title, pictures, and color. Use textbook pp. 141–151.

C 🎤 Fossil News Report

You're the reporter! Break a real fossil story like it's on TV.

Pick one story

- **1938:** A fish called "extinct," the coelacanth, is caught alive!
- **1953:** The Piltdown "ape-man" is exposed as a fake.
- **1980:** Mount St. Helens lays down rock layers in days.

Steps

1. Write a 1–2 minute script: Who? What? When? Where? Why does it matter?
2. Add a pretend interview with a scientist or eyewitness.
3. Record a video or perform it live. Props welcome!

Turn in your script too.

Your 2-Week Plan

DAYS 1–2	Do your jar experiment and pick your Project 2 option.
DAYS 3–5	Take your 1-day picture and finish your jar write-up.
DAYS 6–11	Build, research, or write your Project 2.
DAYS 12–14	Practice presenting and turn in **BOTH** projects!

How You'll Be Graded

What I'm looking for (Do your best! Finish every step and give full effort.)	Points	My Score
🫙 **Project 1: Layers in a Jar**		
Experiment done, with pictures at 1 min, 10 min, and 1 day	20	
Write-up answers all 4 questions and connects to the Flood	20	
Neat work, presented, and turned in on time	10	
⭐ **Project 2: Your Choice**		
Completed every step of the option you chose	20	
Science explanation is clear and correct	20	
Effort, creativity, presented, and turned in on time	10	
TOTAL	100	